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The much-anticipated return of the Hockey India League (HIL) lived up to expectations, providing a crucial platform for emerging talent. New stars made their mark, fresh faces found an opportunity to shine, and young players tested themselves alongside some of the world's best.

Under the watchful eye of India coach Craig Fulton, Jugraj Singh enjoyed a career-defining tournament, showcasing his powerful drag flicks, particularly in the final. Throughout the competition, Jugraj gained invaluable insights from India's premier drag-flicking exponent, Rupinder Pal Singh.

Fulton dubbed the HIL "Jugi's Olympics," hoping that the Rarh Bengal Tigers defender would now step up as a strong alternative to skipper Harmanpreet Singh in short-corner situations.

HIL'S FIVE-FOREIGNER RULE MAY HAVE HINDERED INDIA'S SEARCH FOR A LONG-TERM NO. 1 GOALKEEPER. SEVERAL INDIAN GOALKEEPERS WERE SUBSTITUTED FOR PENALTY STROKES AND SHOOTOUTS

Crowning moment: The Hockey India League concluded with the Shrachi Rarh Bengal Tigers emerging as champion, defeating Hyderabad Toofans at Rourkela's Birsas Munda International Stadium. M. VRDHAN

The Hockey India League's return highlighted emerging talent, **tactical growth**, and intense competition. However, the tournament's success was somewhat marred by concerns over low attendance and scheduling issues.

Defying expectations

Before the tournament began, the Tigers were considered the weakest team due to their squad's age and profile. They did not top the charts for goals scored, goals conceded, circle penetrations, or penalty corner conversion rates. However, they defied expectations, finishing at the top of the group stage after 10 matches and ultimately triumphing over the Hyderabad Toofans —